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Titus

Titus 1:1–9

When Paul greeted Titus, Paul called him his true son in the faith.

The hope and faith that they shared joined them together like family members in God's family.

As an apostle, Paul worked to teach people the truth about who Jesus is.

Understanding this truth and believing it changes the way people live. Because of it they follow Jesus' example for living. Paul called this godly living or holy living.

The truth about Jesus fills people with the hope of living for ever with Christ.

Titus worked together with Paul to help people believe in Jesus.

To do this on Crete, he needed to appoint faithful leaders in the churches.

Many things are required of people who serve as church elders or leaders.

Paul listed ten things that they must do and five things that they mustn't do. This is like the list Paul wrote about church leaders in 1 Timothy 3:1–16.

Above all, church leaders must be firmly committed to the truth about Jesus Christ.

Titus 1:10–16

Some believers in Crete who were Jewish claimed to know God but didn't obey him. They taught things that went against the truth about Jesus. They did this to take advantage of people and take their money.

Paul called these people the circumcision group. They taught that Jesus didn't save Gentiles unless they followed Jewish laws. The laws this group cared about most were the ones that separated Jews from Gentiles. They were about males being circumcised and about things that were considered pure or clean.

Their understanding of what was right and wrong was based on the teachings of other people. It wasn't based on what Jesus taught. Their teachings caused problems for the community of believers and had to be stopped. Jesus taught that nothing people did to their bodies could make them clean or pure (Mark 7:1–23). Paul reminded Titus that Jesus' followers are already pure and accepted by God.

Titus 2:1–15

Paul showed how each one of God's people had important work to do.

They were to treat one another in ways that taught unbelievers about God. These ways were very different from what was common in Crete. In Crete it was common to tell lies, be lazy and eat too much (Titus 1:12).

God's grace taught believers in Crete to say no to sin. It taught them how to live in godly and holy ways.

Believers were to obey Christ in their homes, in their work and in all their relationships. All members of each family should control themselves and treat one another with respect and love. They must be honest, kind and worthy of trust.

They must do this as they wait in hope for Jesus' return. Titus was to teach, correct and encourage the believers about all these things.

Titus 3:1–15

Paul talked about being ready and committed to doing good. God doesn't save people because they do good works. He saves them because he freely gives his kindness, love and mercy.

As people receive God's kindness, they change. They stop being full of hate and evil. They start being gentle and treating others with kindness and love like God does. This happens when God forgives their sins and the Holy Spirit gives them new life.

Some believers in Crete didn't want to do good to others. They preferred to fight and argue about things that didn't matter. They wanted to divide the believers into groups instead of living together in peace. Paul warned Titus to stay away from people like that.

One way Titus was to do good was to help believers who were travelling. Paul wanted Titus to make sure that they had what they needed for their trip. This would be an example to the churches in Crete. The believers were to provide for people when they had needs. That way they would be showing God's kindness and love to everyone.